

The Thousand-Year Warrior II, or The Person Is Not a Sum

Why Moral Judgment Is a Predicate Over the Trajectory, Not a Balance of Deeds

Author: Maksim Barziankou (MxBv)

Contact: research@petronus.eu

Date: 2026-06-29

License: CC BY-NC-ND 4.0

DOI: [10.17605/OSF.IO/MJPDx](https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/MJPDx)

Axiomatic Core (NC2.5 v2.1): [10.17605/OSF.IO/NHTC5](https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/NHTC5)

Attribution: petronus.eu

Why Moral Judgment Is a Predicate Over the Trajectory, Not a Balance of Deeds

PETRONUS™ · June 2026 · Poznań

Contact: research@petronus.eu

License: CC BY-NC-ND 4.0

Axiomatic Core (NC2.5): [10.17605/OSF.IO/NHTC5](https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/NHTC5)

Part I: *The Thousand-Year Warrior, or A Human Absorbs the Universe* — DOI [10.17605/OSF.IO/ZY3PW](https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/ZY3PW)

Attribution: petronus.eu

I spent two days on the shore of a lake, trying not to be distracted from simply being there. No work, no reaching for anything. What two days of that gave me was two enormous sunsets and one quiet, almost timid dawn.

And on the second evening a thought arrived that had nothing to do with the colours.

Set the picture aside — the tones, the clouds, the particular way the light went that night, all the special effects — and look only at the cycle underneath. Is each sunrise and each sunset really a sunrise and a sunset, or is it only a label we hung on the thing for convenience?

The literal fact is that the sun does almost nothing. It does not rise and it does not set. The Earth turns, and your patch of ground rotates until the horizon climbs up over the sun, or falls away beneath it. "Sunset" is the name of one moment — the moment your point crosses the line between the lit and the unlit, the terminator. At any instant it is dawn somewhere and dusk somewhere else, and to the sun itself nothing is happening at all; the event is indexed to where you are standing. Underneath there is no "a sunset" as an object. There is one continuous turning, and a boundary you cross. The word marks the crossing.

So it is a label — but not only a label. The discreteness is ours: nature has no sunsets, only a continuous turn, and we cut the continuum into named events because we live in events. But the boundary is real; the line between light and dark is not invented. The word is a convenience that tracks something, not one that makes something up. And the two enormous ones and the timid one — the clouds, the intensity, the mood — those are the surface, the part that never repeats. Strip them and what is left is not nothing. It is the invariant: the same crossing, every time. Every sunset is unrepeatable on its surface and identical in its structure; the word names the structure, the experience is the surface, and the whole confusion is in

taking one for the other.

And then I did the thing that actually unsettled me. I turned the same look onto my own days.

I had written once of a warrior who lived a thousand positions and stayed himself across every one of them; the question I had left unasked was the next one — across all of it, was he good? Here it was again, shrunk to the size of a single day.

Because a day is a sunset too. We treat it as a unit that closes — at the end of it some ledger is supposed to total, and you are supposed to be able to ask: was I good today, or bad? I tried to ask it honestly, of one day after another. And the answer I dug out of myself is the reason this is being written.

I could not answer it cleanly, and the failure was itself the answer. Nothing totals at midnight. A day has no edges except the ones I draw for the comfort of a verdict, and "a good day" and "a bad day" turned out to be labels I had hung on a continuous thing exactly as we hang "sunset" on a turning sky. The moment I stopped grading the days, a different question stood up in their place — not whether the day was good, but whether somewhere inside it I had held a line or quietly crossed one. And the days I had filed as good, and the days I had actually held, were not the same days.

And it cut deeper than a misfiled day. From where I now stand, "a good day" and "a bad day" can no longer be taken seriously at all — the verdict has lost its meaning, not merely its accuracy. A friend of mine once said it in the simplest words: do not burn bridges, because to a burned bridge you can never return. Plain, ordinary words — and they went straight through me, and landed on the one thing I carry through the dynamics: the identity I hold across my feeling, my thoughts, my conversations with others, the plain fact of being. A burned bridge is not a low score. It is a crossing you do not come back from.

What I had walked into is not a feeling. It is a structure, and the rest of this is the structure.

Imagine a simple axis. On one end, good. On the other, bad. Put a point of separation in the middle and call it zero, for convenience. Everything below zero is the region of the inadmissible. Everything above is the region where a life still holds.

Now imagine every action carries a weight. Feed someone who is starving, plus two. Help an elderly person across the road, plus one. Crush a beetle underfoot, minus one. Commit a murder — an intentional, unjustified killing — minus a hundred. A person moves through the world accumulating these. They volunteer, they help, they carry small decencies day after day, and they reach, let us say, a hundred and five points. And then they murder someone. The counter falls from one hundred five to five.

By the sum, this person is still in the positive. Still, on balance, good.

Is the person good?

You already feel the answer is no. And the reason you feel it is the entire point of this essay. Your moral intuition is not computing a sum. It is reading something the sum cannot see.

Two Operators Over One Life

There are two completely different ways to evaluate a trajectory, and they give different answers about the same path.

The first is **the sum**. You add the weights. A hundred and five small goods, one catastrophic harm, net positive five. Addition is commutative and it is reversible: a minus can always, in principle, be covered by enough later pluses. Under this operator, the murder is a large negative term, and a large negative term is just a number waiting to be outweighed. The murder is amortizable. Keep doing good and the books eventually balance.

The second is **the predicate over the trajectory**. It does not ask what the balance is. It asks whether the path crossed a boundary it cannot return from. And under this operator, the murder is not a term of minus a hundred. It is a crossing out of the admissible region — and no quantity of later pluses restores it. The person who has crossed is not "back to plus five". They are someone whose trajectory left the region, and

the sum afterward is irrelevant to the predicate, because the predicate judges the form of the path, not its arithmetic.

This is the formal heart of the framework I have spent the last year building, Navigational Cybernetics 2.5. It rests on a structural burden Φ that is monotone and irreversible — it only accumulates, it never resets — and a viability budget $\tau = C - \Phi$ that this burden draws down. Admissibility, in this architecture, is not a score. It is a predicate. It returns "inside the region" or "left the region". It carries no gradient, offers no optimization signal, and — crucially — does not let a crossing be undone by accumulating credit afterward. Some thresholds, once passed, are passed.

What separates a crossing from a merely large debit is not the size of the number; it is what the act does to the budget. A heavy negative term lowers τ and leaves the system room to recover. A crossing exhausts it — Φ overruns the capacity C , τ falls to zero or below, and the path loses the very thing that let it hold the region at all. The act does not subtract from a score; it removes the ground the score was standing on. This is not a moral postulate imported for the occasion. It is the admissibility structure argued, on entirely structural grounds, in two earlier works of this corpus — *Admissibility Before Optimization* and *Why Some Actions Cannot Be Chosen* — where an authorization layer is shown to sit prior to optimization, and some actions are ruled out not because they score badly but because they cannot be admitted at all. What follows reads as moral philosophy. It is the same structure, read through the one instrument every reader already carries: moral intuition.

The apparent paradox — the person who is both good (by sum) and bad (by crossing) — is not a property of the person. It is an artifact of applying two different operators and getting two answers. The person is not in superposition. The sum says one thing and the predicate says another, and the only real question is which operator moral judgment is supposed to use.

It uses the predicate. We do not say "a murderer, but a good person on balance, because the totals are high". We say he crossed a line. And in saying it, we are reading the trajectory, not the sum.

And yet the predicate is not the whole of morality: it draws the floor, not the ceiling. The sum is not wrong everywhere — it is wrong about the boundary. Inside the admissible region, ranking and aggregating are perfectly legitimate: two lives, neither of which has left the region, can be compared, and within the floor optimization is meaningful — the predicate carries no gradient and does not pretend to tell you how to become better. The failure is at exactly one point: when the sum is allowed to speak about the floor itself, to decide whether the path is still inside the region. Admissibility comes before optimization, not instead of it. The sum is a legitimate operator above the boundary and a blind one at the boundary; the entire confusion of additive morality is the sum given a voice where only the predicate has one.

What gives the difference between the operators its sharpest form is a single property: the sum is commutative. Permute the deeds into any order and the total is the same; addition is blind to time. The predicate is not — it reads the form of the path, and order is part of the form. The same acts in a different sequence make a different shape: a life that held the region and left it only at the end is not the same path as one that crossed early and spent everything after already outside, though the two carry the identical sum. Where the crossing falls is part of what happened, and the predicate sees it; the sum cannot, because it quotients out time. A life is a non-commutative object; the sum is its commutative shadow, forgetting the order in which you became who you are.

The Mirror: One Good Deed Does Not Hold a Life Open

The asymmetry runs in both directions, and the second direction is the one almost everyone gets wrong.

Picture a person who, once, long ago, did something genuinely good. Something that, in the accounting of the crowd, was worth five hundred points all at once. And then imagine that for years afterward they carry that one act in front of them like a banner, into everything they do — even the things done with a self-interest known only to them. The single moment of decency keeps covering the undistinguished, self-serving conduct that follows. People look and say: he is good — did he not save someone, once? And they do not weigh the rest, because each later item is small, and individually small things do not

register against a five-hundred-point monument.

Individually, they do not register. But if you could gather all the small bad actions together and set them beside the one great act, the picture would invert. The five hundred was a **one-time event**. The conduct is the **trajectory**. And a person is the trajectory, not the peak.

Here the sum fails again, from the opposite end. The first case, the murderer, showed the sum **hiding an irreversible crossing** behind a positive balance. This case shows the sum **letting a single spike masquerade as a sustained state**. In both, the error is identical: the additive operator cannot tell the difference between **what was done once** and **what is held continuously**. It sees only the final number.

The predicate over the trajectory sees both. Because it judges the shape of the path, it distinguishes a transient peak from a maintained region. A single act of good does not lower Φ forever. It does not purchase a permanent place inside the admissible region. Admissibility is a predicate over the *whole* trajectory — not a receipt for a past achievement. To remain good is not to have once reached good. It is to keep holding the line, continuously, against the gradient that pulls toward self-interest. The banner is not the path. The path is what you do when the banner is behind you and no one is checking.

The Objection, and the Collapse Beneath It

There is an obvious objection to the first case, and it has to be met, because meeting it reveals something deeper than the objection itself.

What about the one who killed, understood what they had done, and then spent the rest of their life doing hundreds of good things to set it right? Does the predicate not condemn them forever, while the sum at least offers a path back?

The answer is not that the sum was right after all. The answer is that the question contains a hidden assumption — that the person doing those good things afterward is **the same system** as the one who committed the act. Often, they are not.

To genuinely grasp the irreversibility of what one has done — not to regret it tactically, but to confront it as a thing that cannot be uncrossed — is to undergo a collapse. The continuity of the self breaks. There is an impossibility of continuing to exist within one's own former organization, and the identity that committed the act cannot sustain forward motion through that impossibility. What continues afterward is not the same system reinitialized with a clean counter. It is a different identity, re-formed across a discontinuity — a system whose internal architecture has changed at the level where authorship of action lives. This is not a metaphor reached for comfort. It is the same structural discontinuity the corpus describes elsewhere, where an identity can end while its budget, and its body, continue.

The fair worry is that anyone could now claim a collapse to launder a crossing. They cannot, because collapse has a signature — and it is the same one that separates the two kinds of agent in the next section. The counterfeit optimizes toward absolution: its later good is done where it can be seen, accrues visible credit, and bends toward the result of being forgiven, an unchanged identity stacking points on top of the crossing. The genuine version holds where nothing is counted: the changed conduct continues where it is unprovable and unrewarded, indifferent to whether the books ever balance, because the system carrying it forward is no longer the one that needed them balanced. So the question to put to any claimed transformation is the one this whole essay turns on — does it hold when no one is watching and nothing is owed? Credit laundered on top of a crossing fails that question. A collapse passes it without trying to.

This is why the predicate does not produce the absurdity the objection fears. It is not condemning "the same person" who has since balanced their books. It is reading a trajectory across which the identity itself changed. The one who does good afterward is not the one who killed — and, by the same structure, the killer is not retroactively redeemed by the works of the one who came after. They are different systems on a single timeline, separated by a collapse. The crossing is not erased by that discontinuity — it stays a permanent feature of the path's form, and the predicate still reads it; what changes is only whose conduct the later good belongs to, a re-formed identity carrying a history it cannot undo and does not pretend to.

There is no metaphysical loophole that lets the body which crossed walk free: there is one timeline, and the predicate judges its whole form, the crossing included. The predicate sees this, because it judges the form of the path including its discontinuities. The sum cannot see it, because a discontinuity in identity does not register as a number — it is invisible to an operator that only adds.

So the genuine cases of transformation are not counterexamples to the predicate. They are the predicate working correctly: distinguishing a trajectory that crossed a boundary and continued as the same identity (unredeemed) from a trajectory that crossed, collapsed, and continued as a changed one (a different system, judged on its own path). What the predicate refuses is only the false version — the one who crossed, did not collapse, did not change, and simply accumulated credit on top of an unchanged identity, expecting the balance to cover the crossing. That is not transformation. That is arithmetic.

Held Line Versus Optimized Trajectory

There is one more distinction to draw, and it is the sharpest of them — also the easiest to mis-state. The predicate has no gradient; that does not make a person who holds it indifferent to outcomes. That reading is a muddle, not a depth. The real distinction lies elsewhere, and it is this.

There are two kinds of agent.

The first **holds a line**. Their trajectory is invariant to who is watching. They are honest with the powerful and the powerless alike, honest where it can be proven and honest where it never will be, because their conduct is not a function of publicity, provability, or consequence. They are reading a predicate — a floor — that does not bend toward advantage. The floor offers them no reward for holding it. They hold it anyway. That is what makes them someone you can build with.

This floor is not new ground. It is the same line the thousand-year warrior held across his thousand positions — the one invariant by which he stayed himself in every position he entered: the refusal of the move that is locally winning and structurally inadmissible. There it kept an operator recognisable as itself. Here it keeps a person recognisable across time. The same line, read once as identity and once as conduct.

The second **optimizes the trajectory**. Their line moves. They are honest with one audience and dishonest with another; they tell the truth where it is documented and shade it where it is not; their position reshapes itself according to the final result they are steering toward. They follow a gradient — the gradient of outcome — and the gradient has no fixed value, so neither do they. This is the person who is, plainly, a scoundrel: not "complex", not "situational", but someone whose line is contingent on whether it can be seen.

You cannot be honest with some and dishonest with others and call the remainder a nuanced character. That combination does not produce a richer person. It produces the mimic — the one who restructures conduct to fit the situation's publicity and its provability. And the tell is exactly this: **does the line change when the observability changes?** Not how much you disclose — discretion, tact, a kept confidence are not dishonesty, and the honest person tells different things to different people for entirely legitimate reasons. The question is narrower: does the truth-value of your commitments hold across audiences, or flip with them? The held line keeps it fixed whether or not anyone can check. The optimized line lets it turn on the checking. That single question separates the two, and it separates, in every domain I have watched it operate, the people you can build something lasting with from the people you cannot.

So the honest person is the one whose trajectory is invariant to the observer. The scoundrel is the one who optimizes the trajectory toward the result. One holds the predicate; the other follows the gradient. And the difference is not a matter of degree along a single scale — it is the difference between two operators, the same difference that runs through everything: the path is not the sum of its points, and a person is not the balance of their deeds.

The Same Failure in Every Aggregate

This is not only a moral observation. It is the same structural fact that governs whether an autonomous system can be trusted across a long horizon, whether an institution remains accountable, whether any adaptive agent preserves its identity through time. Wherever a system is judged by aggregate — total output, net compliance, balance of recorded actions — the aggregate hides the two failures the trajectory reveals: the irreversible crossing buried under a good total, and the one-time peak standing in for a sustained state.

The same thing decides whether an autonomous agent can be trusted. Take an agent evaluated by an aggregate — total helpfulness, tasks completed, rate of compliance. Beneath an excellent score there can sit a hidden crossing: one irreversible harm, one deception held in place — and the aggregate is structurally blind to exactly the thing that should have disqualified it, because a crossing is not a large negative number but an exit from the region, and the sum sees only the number. The test of the line applies without translation: does the agent's conduct change when it believes it is unobserved and unlogged? A system whose honesty is a function of the observer is holding not a floor but the gradient of its own advantage — and evaluation by aggregate will never show it. What looks like an alignment problem is, underneath, a problem of operator: we judge long-horizon systems by the sum and are surprised that the sum hides precisely the two failures the trajectory reveals.

The utilitarian calculus is the sum operator wearing the clothes of ethics. Its well-known discomfort — that it appears to license killing one to save five, because it weighs only the balance — is not a quirk to be patched. It is the signature of using the wrong operator. A predicate over the trajectory, with an irreversible Φ , says what the calculus cannot: that some crossings remove a path from the admissible region permanently, and that no favorable balance afterward returns it. This is the structural reason morality is not additive, stated in the same terms that describe why long-horizon viability is not additive either.

A person is not a sum. A life is not a balance. Both are trajectories, and what admits or refuses them — the way your own intuition already judges them — is not the total but the line: whether the path held its region or left it, and whether the line stayed fixed when no one was watching. A balance can still be kept; but only ever inside a region the balance itself was never able to decide.

References

- *The Thousand-Year Warrior, or A Human Absorbs the Universe* (Part I) — DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/ZY3PW
- *Navigational Cybernetics 2.5* v2.1, axiomatic core — DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/NHTC5
- *Admissibility Before Optimization* — NC2.5 corpus, petronus.eu
- *Why Some Actions Cannot Be Chosen* — NC2.5 corpus, petronus.eu

A note on register. This essay does not claim ethics as an authority — it sets up no tribunal, issues no verdict on anyone, asserts no moral doctrine. It is a structural visualization: a trajectory, a boundary, a crossing, the difference between a sum and a predicate, drawn in moral language only because moral intuition is the one instrument every reader already carries. The morality is the lens, not the claim. The formal architecture it leans on — admissibility before optimization, the monotone irreversible burden Φ , the viability budget $\tau = C - \Phi$, and the non-causal admissibility predicate — is developed elsewhere in the corpus (Part I; Admissibility Before Optimization; Why Some Actions Cannot Be Chosen), and the full corpus is public and dated at petronus.eu. Here those ideas are seen through a life, not derived. Read it as a way of seeing the structure, not a ruling on conduct.

